

Inside the administrative reset that transformed J&K cricket

Mithun Manhas believes Jammu and Kashmir's journey doesn't end with winning the Ranji Trophy. Rather, it is about **creating an identity** and giving young cricketers in the region a pathway that didn't exist before.

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Five years ago, when Mithun Manhas returned home as part of the three-member sub-committee appointed by the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI), he knew sentiment alone wouldn't rebuild cricket in Jammu and Kashmir.

A former captain of the State side and a seasoned First-Class cricketer, Manhas had seen both the promise and the pitfalls of the system. The team had reached the Ranji Trophy quarterfinals a year earlier, but the COVID-19 pandemic had stalled momentum. Infrastructure was weak. Pathways were unclear. Morale was fragile.

"The vision was simple," Manhas tells *Sportstar*. "Put the players first. If they need something, give it to them. Create an environment where performance becomes the only currency."

Five years on, that philosophy has culminated in Jammu and Kashmir

clinching its maiden Ranji Trophy title. "They've made us proud," Manhas, now the president of the BCCI, says. "Back home, thousands of boys and girls are watching them. They are heroes now. They've already changed the mindset."

From promise to process

Since making its Ranji Trophy debut in 1959-60, Jammu and Kashmir was rarely viewed as a heavyweight. There were flashes, including a knockout qualification in 2013-14 and another quarterfinal run in 2019-20 under mentor Irfan Pathan. However, consistency eluded the side.

When Manhas returned in 2021, the reality was stark. "There was nothing," he recalls. "Even the square was more of a formality. Wickets were not up to the mark. Structurally, we had to start from scratch."

During one of his visits to the Jammu Kashmir Cricket Association office, soon after taking charge, Manhas met Umran Malik, who had come looking for cricket balls. "He was already an IPL player by then, so

I was surprised to see that he had to struggle to get some basic stuff. We got the office opened and provided him with the balls to practise," Manhas says.

With Brigadier (retd.) Anil Gupta handling administration and strong backing from then BCCI secretary Jay Shah, the rebuilding began in earnest.

Manhas is candid about Shah's role. "He was the first BCCI secretary to visit JKCA after its affiliation in 1957. That visit changed things. He spoke to players, saw the facilities, understood the gaps. After that, whenever we needed something, support was there."

But financial backing alone doesn't build a cricketing culture.

The talent hunt that changed everything

The first major step was launching a statewide talent hunt in April 2022 — something that had never been executed systematically before. During his stint with J&K, Pathan had started identifying players from the Jammu and Kashmir regions, but